RESILIENT VILLAGES ZIMBABWE

SAFEGUARDING POLICY

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1. Preamble & Core Organizational Values

Resilient Villages Zimbabwe (PVO 74/20) is dedicated to facilitating sustainable community development, empowerment, and resilience across rural and vulnerable populations. Essential to our mission is an uncompromised commitment to maintaining an ethical environment where human rights are upheld, dignified treatment is guaranteed, and all individuals—particularly children and vulnerable adults—are protected from harm, exploitation, and abuse.

Our safeguarding commitments are anchored in our core organizational values:

Value	Operational Definition & Safeguarding Application
Integrity	Operating with absolute honesty, strong moral principles, and transparent ethics in all internal and community engagements.
Transparency	Maintaining clear, accessible organizational procedures and visible operational standards regarding safeguarding policies and actions.
Accountability	Taking absolute ownership of individual and institutional actions, enforcing policy compliance, and ensuring zero-tolerance for misconduct.
Community Participation	Actively involving local beneficiaries and structures in identifying risks, designing protective mechanisms, and establishing localized feedback systems.
Stewardship	Exercising responsible care, management, and oversight of human resources, trust, power, and physical/financial assets entrusted to the organization.
Inclusivity	Ensuring equal protection, non-discrimination, and dignity for all individuals regardless of

Value	Operational Definition & Safeguarding Application
	gender, age, disability, ethnicity, or socioeconomic status.
Teamwork	Fostering a collaborative organizational culture focused on shared responsibility for safety, vigilance, mutual support, and joint problem-solving.

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2. Statement of Policy & Safeguarding Definition

2.1 Statement of Policy

Resilient Villages Zimbabwe strictly enforces a **Zero-Tolerance Policy** against any form of exploitation, abuse, sexual harassment, neglect, or harm committed by its personnel, representatives, or associated partners against beneficiaries, children, vulnerable adults, or community members.

2.2 Safeguarding Definition

Within Resilient Villages Zimbabwe, **Safeguarding** is defined as the preventative, proactive, and responsive actions taken to protect individuals—specifically children, adults at risk, and vulnerable community members—from suffering harm, abuse, neglect, exploitation, or discrimination resulting from contact with our operations, programs, personnel, or partner entities.

Safeguarding operates across three primary pillars:

- **Prevention:** Proactive measures to create safe environments, secure recruitment, and robust risk assessments.
- **Reporting:** Clear, accessible, confidential, and safe channels for reporting suspected or actual violations.
- **Response:** Timely, fair, thorough, and confidential investigation and management of all reported incidents.

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3. Policy Objectives

The overarching objectives of this Safeguarding Policy are to:

- Establish explicit organizational standards and responsibilities for all staff, board members, consultants, volunteers, and operational associates.
- Prevent barred, unsuitable, or high-risk individuals from joining the organization through rigorous vetting and screening procedures.
- Ensure immediate, prompt, evidence-based, and survivor-centered action is taken whenever allegations or suspicions of abuse or misconduct arise.
- Establish clear boundaries to prevent inappropriate contact, power imbalances, and abusive behavior across all operational activities.
- Empower communities, staff, and beneficiaries with accessible feedback and reporting mechanisms to flag risks safely.

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4. Classification of Types of Abuse

To ensure clarity and awareness across all operational levels, Resilient Villages Zimbabwe categorizes and defines types of abuse as follows:

Category of Abuse	Detailed Description & Operational Context
Physical Abuse	Any non-accidental physical force, violence, or bodily harm inflicted upon a person. This includes hitting, slapping, pushing, burning, restraining, physical intimidation, or depriving an individual of basic biological needs.
Sexual Abuse & Exploitation	Any actual or attempted intrusion, force, coercion, or abuse of power of a sexual nature. This encompasses transactional sex, solicitation of sexual favors in exchange for assistance or goods, unauthorized touching, rape, exposure to explicit material, and non-consensual sexual engagement.
Emotional & Psychological Abuse	Non-physical acts that undermine emotional well-being, dignity, or self-worth. This includes verbal abuse, humiliation, intimidation, threats of

Category of Abuse	Detailed Description & Operational Context
	violence or abandonment, public shaming, isolation, gaslighting, or persistent harassment.
Financial & Material Abuse	The unauthorized, illegal, or improper use, exploitation, or theft of an individual's funds, assets, property, entitlement, or benefits. This includes extortion, withholding project aid, coercion regarding personal assets, or fraudulent misuse of funds intended for beneficiaries.

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5. Organizational Prevention Commitments

Resilient Villages Zimbabwe implements strict preventative controls to mitigate risks of harm and abuse across all operations:

5.1 Safe Environments & Operational Processes

- Design and implement community activities that prioritize physical safety, privacy, and protection.
- Ensure field activities involving children or vulnerable adults maintain adequate staff supervision ratio policies ("two-adult rule").

5.2 Safe Communication & Information Sharing

- Enforce strict guidelines regarding media, photography, and video recording. Written/verbal informed consent must be secured before capturing images of service users.
- Strictly prohibit photographs that depict subjects in a vulnerable, dignified, or sexualized manner. Children's full names or precise locations must never be published alongside media assets.

5.3 Safer Recruitment & Background Checks

- Mandatory background checks, police clearance certificates, and past performance reference checks for all prospective employees, board members, consultants, and volunteers before appointment.
- Inclusion of explicit safeguarding criteria and behavioral inquiries during candidate interview stages.

5.4 Capacity Building & Continuous Training

- Comprehensive safeguarding orientation during employee onboarding.
- Mandatory annual refresher training for all active staff, focal persons, and board members to review legal standards, reporting protocols, and risk management.

5.5 Institutional Safeguarding Advisory Structure

- Designation of trained **Safeguarding Focal Persons** at both head office and operational field levels to act as advisory authorities, manage risk assessments, and guide reporting processes.

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6. Response Mechanisms & Reporting Procedures

Resilient Villages Zimbabwe enforces structured, confidential, and rapid procedures for receiving, assessing, and responding to safeguarding concerns.

None



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|  determine scope, legal obligations, and protection needs             |
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+-------------------------------------------------------------------------+
|                      INVESTIGATION & FORMAL RESPONSE                    |
|   Confidential investigation, disciplinary action, referral to law     |
|   enforcement (if legal breach), and continuous survivor support       |
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6.1 Feedback & Reporting Channels

- **Internal Reporting:** Staff members who observe or suspect safeguarding breaches must report the incident to their direct supervisor or the Safeguarding Focal Person within 24 hours.
- **Confidential Hotlines:** Secure, independent communication channels (phone line, designated secure email, physical suggestion boxes) are established for anonymous or direct disclosures by staff, service users, and community members.

6.2 Assessment & Investigation Principles

- **Evidence-Based:** All allegations are systematically reviewed and investigated based on objective evidence, witness statements, and formal documentation.
- **Survivor-Centered:** Proceedings prioritize the dignity, safety, emotional support, and confidentiality of the victim/survivor throughout the investigation process.
- **Legal Compliance:** In instances involving criminal acts (e.g., child abuse, sexual assault), reports will be escalated to national law enforcement authorities in compliance with Zimbabwean legislation.

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7. Formal Approval & Authorization Block

This Safeguarding Policy has been formally reviewed, approved, and enacted by the Board of Directors and Executive Leadership of Resilient Villages Zimbabwe.

Approving Authority	Name & Title	Signature	Date
Board Governance	**Sr Stellar Gaihai Khumalo**Board Chairperson	Person	January 2022
Executive Leadership	**Jerald Ndungwani**Executive Director	Person	January 2022

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8. Appendix: Employee & Associate Acknowledgement and Binding Agreement Form

This form must be completed, signed, and submitted to the Human Resources / Safeguarding Office upon employment, appointment, or execution of contract.

Acknowledgement & Agreement

I, **Person**, acknowledge that I have received, read, understood, and agreed to abide by the **Resilient Villages Zimbabwe Safeguarding Policy & Code of Conduct**.

I explicitly commit to:

1. Upholding the highest standards of ethics, integrity, and safety in my interactions with children, vulnerable adults, community members, and colleagues.
2. Refraining from any form of physical, sexual, emotional, or financial abuse, harassment, or exploitation.
3. Reporting any suspected, observed, or disclosed safeguarding violations through the established organizational channels immediately.
4. Complying with all instructions, investigations, and preventative procedures instituted by Resilient Villages Zimbabwe.

I understand that failure to comply with this policy, or engagement in abusive behaviors, will result in formal disciplinary action, up to and including immediate termination of employment or contract, and potential criminal referral to relevant law enforcement authorities.

Full Name: Person
Role / Position: Person

National ID / Passport Number: Person
Duty Station / Location: Place

Signature: Person
Date: Date